



Decision-making in the United Nations General Assembly: A comprehensive database of resolution-related decisions

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Abstract

Existing United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) voting databases provide excellent coverage of UNGA voting on resolutions adopted by roll-call vote. These databases, however, have known limitations: The United Nations Digital Library only covers final decisions on adopted resolutions, not prior resolution-related decisions nor decisions on failed resolutions. Coverage of roll-call votes in the widely-used database provided by Bailey, Strezhnev and Voeten is broader but reflects limitations in the historical datasets on which the database is built (e.g., the Inter-university Consortium for Political and Social Research dataset). As a result, voting coverage and what is reported vary over time. In this paper, we present a new dataset that expands and improves the consistency of the UNGA decisions covered. We provide comparisons of our database with other UNGA datasets and explore the implications of more complete data for existing and future research.

Keywords UNGA · Voting · Preferences · International organizations · Comprehensive database

JEL Classification F33 · F35 · F53 · O19

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1 Introduction

A considerable literature draws in one way or another on United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) voting data. These data are used to study similarities in voting behavior between states and their effects on various outcomes, or to infer policy preferences and geopolitical alignment. Using voting behavior in the UN provides a relatively consistent measure that is available over a long time period. Authors of such studies primarily rely on voting data from the United Nations website (United Nations Digital Library or UNDL) or a more comprehensive dataset by Bailey et al. (2017, henceforth BSV). BSV data are heavily used: for 2023 alone, we found 86 journal articles using their dataset (including eight in this journal).

Both sources are, however, incomplete when it comes to decisions by UNGA delegates. The UN website only reports votes on adopted resolutions. BSV includes those resolutions passed by roll-call vote and, for some periods, roll-call votes on failed draft resolutions, on amendments and on motions, and separate votes. BSV also includes some procedural votes unrelated to resolutions for some UNGA sessions. The partial coverage of both datasets can be problematic when the research question or method requires coherent, systematic inclusion criteria for the decisions covered.

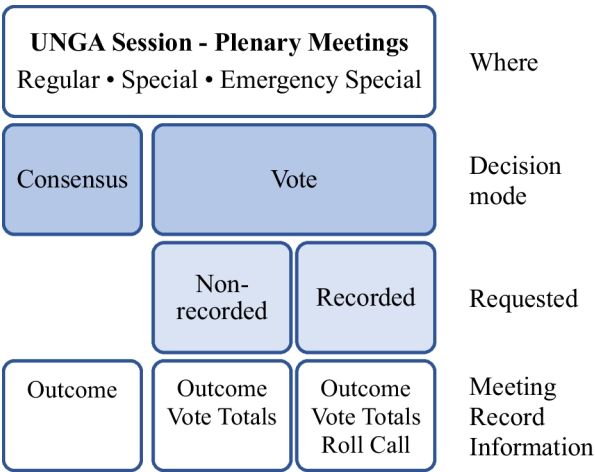
Our database on UNGA decision-making (henceforth UNGA-DM; available at <https://unvotes.unige.ch>) uses such a systematic inclusion criterion: UNGA-DM includes all decisions on resolution-related matters in UNGA plenary sessions, from the first session in 1946 to the 77th (including special and emergency special sessions, with yearly updates available online), and excludes all decisions not related to UNGA resolutions or not in a UNGA plenary session. These different approaches have a substantial impact. Through the end of UNGA Regular Session 76, UNGA-DM includes 6,202 resolution-related roll-call votes that are also in BSV, excludes 174 BSV votes that are not resolution-related, adds another 1,110 resolution-related votes that BSV omits, and tracks an additional 15,302 resolution-related decisions made by non-recorded vote or by consensus.

The next section outlines the decision-making process at the UNGA, then briefly surveys existing UNGA voting datasets and their limitations. Section three describes how UNGA-DM was created and compares it with BSV's 2023 dataset. Section four reviews the organization and structure of the UNGA-DM database, as well as different ways to access it. Section five uses UNGA-DM to replicate several studies. As the results show, using complete data on UNGA resolution-related votes in some instances leads to changes in inferences. We conclude by recalling the advantages of these new data on UNGA decision-making.

2 UNGA decision-making and existing datasets

UNGA regular sessions generally start on the Tuesday of the second work-week of September. Special sessions and emergency special sessions (called by United Nations Security Council (UNSC) or UNGA membership) can follow a different

Fig. 1 UNGA-DM Coverage. Background on UN General Assembly decision-making process. The UNGA holds plenary meetings for regular sessions, special sessions, and emergency special sessions. At these meetings, decisions are either without a vote (by consensus) or by vote. There are non-recorded votes (e.g., a show of hands) and recorded roll-call votes. UNGA meeting records (which for plenary sessions include verbatim transcripts) indicate the outcome for all decisions, vote totals for votes, and roll calls for roll-call votes



schedule.¹ All member-states are eligible to participate on an equal basis in decision-making in these plenary sessions, unless their membership is suspended, e.g., because of unpaid dues. Decisions are by consensus, by non-recorded vote, or, if requested, by recorded (roll-call) vote.² When there is voting, member-state delegates can vote in favor or against or they may abstain. Delegates may also be absent. Information about UNGA meetings (including decisions) is available in verbatim meeting records. For consensus decisions, meeting records only state that the measure was adopted. For non-recorded votes, meeting records report totals in favor, against and abstaining, as well as whether the measure was adopted. Recorded votes include in addition a list of member-states in favor, against and abstaining. Starting in 1954, meeting records indicate if delegations subsequently wished to amend their vote; such “amended votes” do not influence the official outcome. Measures put to a vote pass if the number in favor exceeds those against, except for important measures that require a two-thirds majority.³ Figure 1 summarizes this information.

Draft resolutions are drawn from committee reports or submitted by member-states directly to the UNGA either in writing or orally. Prior to a final decision on the draft resolution, it can be amended or parts of the draft resolution—or of an amendment—dropped via separate votes on words, phrases, sentences, paragraphs or sections.⁴ This process can include various types of motions. These include motions to vote or not vote, motions to suspend discussion, motions to adjourn or to close debate, motions to require a two-thirds majority, motions for division (to request separate

¹ Special sessions cover a specific pressing issue, e.g., apartheid or disarmament. Emergency special sessions are in response to ongoing conflict when the UNSC is deadlocked, e.g., over Russia’s invasion of Ukraine.

² From March 31 to August 31, 2020, the UNGA adopted measures through a silent absence-of-objection procedure without meetings or meeting records due to the COVID-19 pandemic. We treat these as consensus decisions.

³ Certain categories are automatically important (e.g., budget items); other measures can be declared important if a motion to do so passes.

⁴ BSV refers to separate votes as paragraph votes.

votes for individual parts of a draft resolution or amendment), motions to consider the competence of the UNGA to adopt a measure, and motions to reconsider prior decisions. Draft resolutions typically contain both preambular and operative paragraphs. If any operative paragraphs or portions thereof survive the process, there is a final decision on the (amended) draft resolution as a whole. As mentioned above, in the case of roll-call votes, member delegates may subsequently inform the UN Secretariat that they wish to have their vote recorded differently. We refer to the former as the original vote and the latter as the amended vote. All this activity is recorded in UN meeting records. Draft resolutions that pass become resolutions, are assigned a resolution ID (e.g., A/RES/75/24, “The Syrian Golan”), and are tracked by the UN’s online database, the UNDL. Draft resolutions that fail to pass are not assigned a resolution ID. Figure 2 summarizes this information.

The UNDL provides information for the final passage of resolutions in digital form. It does not report other resolution-related decisions, i.e., decisions on amendments, motions, separate votes, nor on final passage votes on failed resolutions.

The Inter-University Consortium for Political and Social Research (ICPSR) database originated with Wrigley’s (1971) study of UN roll-call voting. This dataset has a greater breadth of coverage but was produced in stages through 1985. As a result, the various files that make-up the ICPSR dataset use different vote inclusion criteria. From 1946 to 1974, ICPSR contains all recorded votes in plenary meetings, including a small number of votes not related to any resolution. From 1975 to 1985, ICPSR only reports recorded votes for final passage of resolutions, excluding other recorded votes, such as failed resolutions. Recorded votes for the UN’s six main committees (which are committees of the whole) are covered in a number of the ICPSR files.

BSV builds on ICPSR data through 1985 (with corrections from other scholars including Gartzke and Jo (2006) and Kim and Russett (1996); see BSV’s codebook) and extend the dataset by drawing on the United Nations Bibliographic Information System (UNBIS, the predecessor to UNDL) and various official documents. This dataset is updated periodically and available on Harvard’s Dataverse website. Nonetheless, several holes in the dataset persist, especially for more recent sessions, due to reliance on the UNDL (see Fig. 3 as well as additional discussion below).

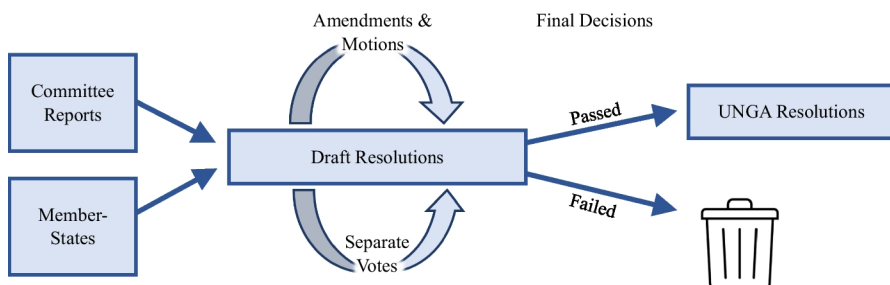


Fig. 2 Decision-making process. Process by which UNGA approves resolutions. Draft resolutions are submitted to the UNGA by its committees or directly by member-states. Before a final decision, a draft resolution may be subject to revision via amendments (which add, revise, or delete text), motions, and separate votes

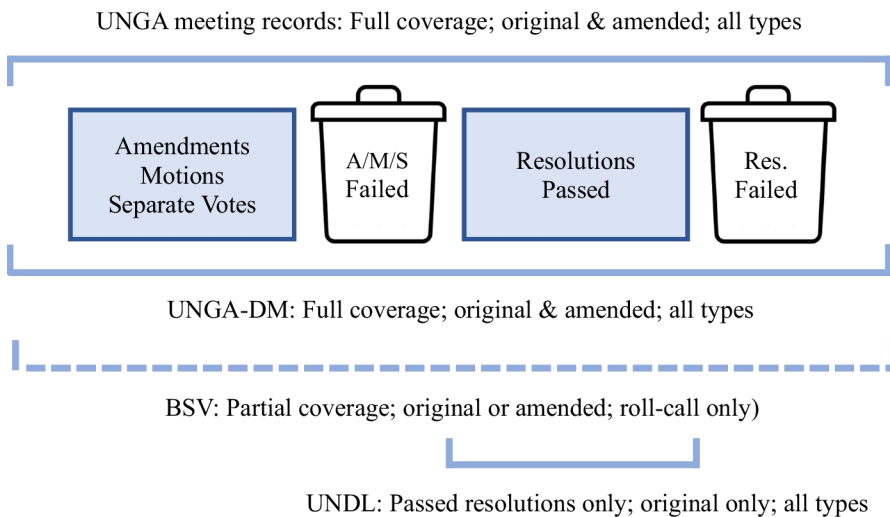


Fig. 3 Database coverage. Coverage of different data sources. UNGA meeting records cover everything but.pdf quality varies, requiring manual processing for earlier sessions. The UNGA-DM dataset covers every resolution-related decision. BSV dataset has partial coverage, only reporting roll-call votes and, among these, missing some failed votes and some amendments, motions, and separate votes. When member-state delegations amend their votes, BSV sometimes reports the original vote, sometimes the amended vote. The UNDL dataset reports only final passage decisions (consensus, non-recorded votes, and roll-call votes), only original votes, and only resolutions that are adopted

3 UNGA-DM: Comparative descriptors, new features

The dataset introduced in this paper, UNGA-DM, covers all resolution-related decisions. We use the UNDL as a starting point for information on successful final passage votes and supplement this with information on failed votes from the *Index to Proceedings of the General Assembly* (www.un.org/library/page/index-proceedings) and associated voting data gleaned from UNGA meeting records. We also use the latter to identify all resolution-related decisions. For roll-call votes, this is done in conjunction with voting data from the ICPSR dataset through session 29; from session 30 on, voting data are scraped from the meeting records.⁵ Where data sources overlap, we conduct numerous validation procedures.⁶ As all these data relate to various documents and features, a relational database stores the information in eight distinct data frames, which allows for queries and downloads. For a full description of the data collection process see the codebook available on the UNGA-DM website.

⁵ Meeting record.pdf quality prior to session 49 is poor. For sessions 30 to 48, automated data collection is limited to roll-call vote data and subject to extensive manual corrections. Higher quality.pdfs starting with session 49 allow automated identification and classification of decisions, in addition to collection of roll-call data.

⁶ For example, if UNDL and ICPSR disagree or if reported vote totals from either source do not match roll-call data, we consult the underlying meeting record. If reported vote totals in the meeting record do not match vote totals calculated from the roll-call data in that record, we consult French, Spanish, or Russian versions of the meeting record.

To demonstrate the usefulness of the UNGA-DM database we compare it to voting data provided by BSV, then highlight some additional features. For the BSV dataset, we use the file “UNVotes.RData” on Erik Voeten’s Harvard Dataverse page, dated July 25, 2023, which contains raw vote data for UNGA regular sessions 1 to 76, as well as special and emergency special sessions.⁷

As a starting point, some basic descriptors about both datasets are helpful. BSV covers decisions with a recorded vote. UNGA-DM includes these and 15,302 decisions adopted without a vote (consensus decisions) or by non-recorded vote (where totals are known but not individual countries’ votes). Below we focus primarily on recorded votes. BSV includes 6,376 decisions with a recorded vote, and 900,881 country-level votes (counting “in favor”, “against”, and “abstaining” as votes). BSV data on countries being members but not voting (being absent) are not straightforward to decipher.⁸ UNGA-DM includes 7,312 decisions by recorded vote, and 1,050,340 country-level votes (counting “in favor”, “against”, and “abstaining”). UNGA-DM also reports 116,967 cases where a country was a UN member but did not vote.⁹

UNGA-DM figures cited above are based on roll-call votes at the time of voting, not amended votes. In 5,735 cases, delegations subsequently informed the UN secretariat that they wished to amend their vote (see above).¹⁰ UNGA-DM provides original and amended votes separately. BSV reports one vote per country per decision; in 1,505 of 5,735 cases, the BSV vote is the amended one. The BSV codebook does not address this issue and so does not explain the criteria for deciding which vote to report.

The overlap of the two datasets covers 6,202 UNGA decisions (97% of BSV votes and 85% of UNGA-DM recorded votes). Agreement between the two datasets on these votes is very good at 99.5%. The main difference between the datasets is which decisions they cover; if we include all decisions by recorded vote covered by UNGA-DM (with the BSV member-state’s vote then set to “not voting” if that decision does not appear in BSV), agreement falls to 82.9%. Figure 4 presents these latter figures by year, indicating substantial variation after 1974.

The main driver of these differences is the types of votes covered. UNGA-DM covers all resolution-related votes (amendments, motions, separate votes and final passage votes, whether the measure passed or not). BSV coverage varies over time; for the most recent years, BSV warns users that the dataset does not include amendments or failed votes. Figure 5 breaks down the type of recorded votes missing from BSV by year. Missing votes spike after 1974 and again toward the end of the time period. The largest category missing is separate votes.

⁷ BSV includes partial coverage of regular session 77; we drop these observations.

⁸ BSV’s “member” variable has values “1”, “9”, and “NA”. For 1946–1996 and 2014, entries with member=NA always have vote=9 (not voting); in other years, member=NA is used less consistently.

⁹ This includes 107,438 cases where a delegation was eligible to vote but did not (i.e., was absent) and 9,529 cases where the delegation was not eligible to vote due to suspension (see Coggins & Morse, 2024), which is coded in UNGA-DM.

¹⁰ In 4,406 of these cases, the delegation had not previously voted. The most common change is from not voting to voting in favor (3,972).

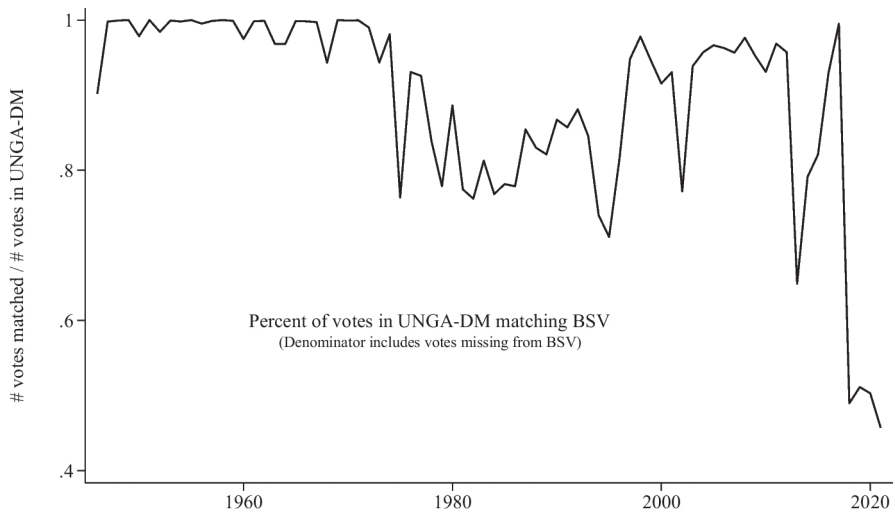


Fig. 4 UNGA-DM/BSV voting agreement. Year-by-year share of member-state roll-call original votes in UNGA-DM that are the same as member-state roll-call vote in BSV. Numerator is the number of identical member-state votes; denominator is the number of member-state votes in UNGA-DM

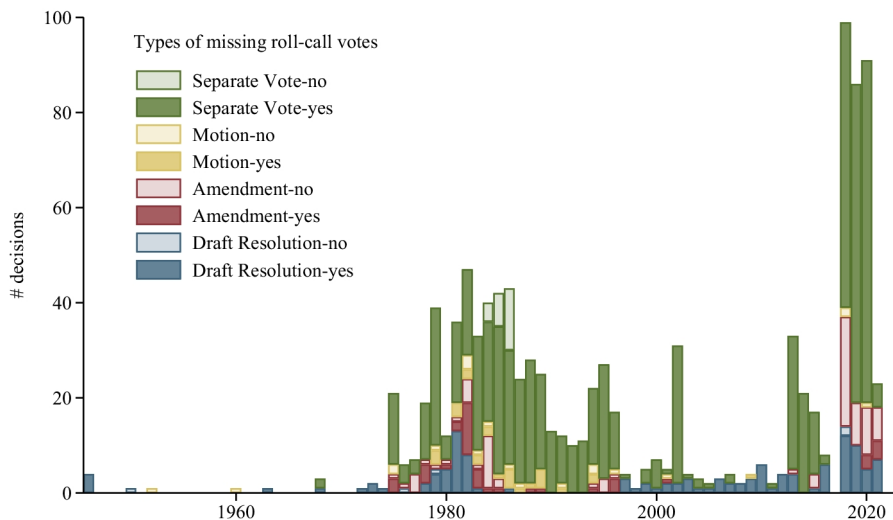


Fig. 5 Missing from BSV, by year and type. Roll-call votes not covered by BSV. Figure distinguishes between topic of vote (draft resolution, amendment, motion, and separate vote) and outcome of vote (passed or failed to pass). There are more missing roll-call votes after 1974. The largest category of missing roll-call votes is separate votes that passed though some years also have a sizeable number of missing draft resolutions that passed or amendments that failed

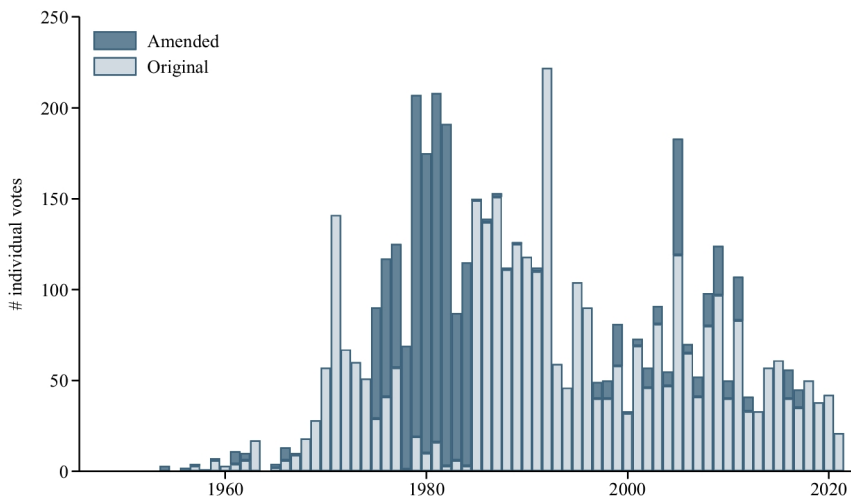


Fig. 6 BSV reporting by year. Whether BSV reports original vote or amended vote. BSV reports one vote (yes, no, abstain) per member-state. UNGA-DM reports the original vote and the amended vote because since 1954 member-states sometimes ask to have their vote amended ex post. The figure shows all such cases (by year) and indicates whether BSV's reported vote is the original vote (which is used for deciding the outcome of the vote) or the subsequent amended vote

Figure 6 switches to the country-vote level to explore BSV's reporting of amended votes. Between 1975 and 1984 and again in 2005, BSV often reports the amended vote.

Differences between the two datasets depend on coverage, whether the amended vote is reported, and data errors. By far the largest source of differences is coverage. Looking again at the country-vote level, there are 1,505 cases where BSV reports amended votes (not original votes) and 2,601 errors where the BSV vote matches neither the original nor the amended vote but 193,569 individual country-level votes missing due to incomplete BSV coverage.¹¹

Figure 7 summarizes the impact of these differences on a commonly used statistic, Signorino and Ritter's (1999) *S*-score that reflects the similarity between two countries' voting records. We use both datasets to calculate *S*-scores for the U.S. The *S*-score equals one for countries that always vote with the U.S., -1 for countries that always vote against the U.S., and a number in-between for countries with a mixed record. Figure 7 presents yearly correlations between annual *S*-scores calculated using BSV data and using UNGA-DM data. The top panel uses all recorded votes in each dataset; the bottom panel uses only recorded votes identified as important by the U.S. State Department in its annual report to Congress (as tracked by the dataset in question). The State Department reports began in 1984 (covering 1983, Session 38 voting); the most recent report covers 2021. BSV includes this variable through 2017.

¹¹ These are largely due to the "legacy" nature of BSV, reflecting different approaches of the various contributors to the data.

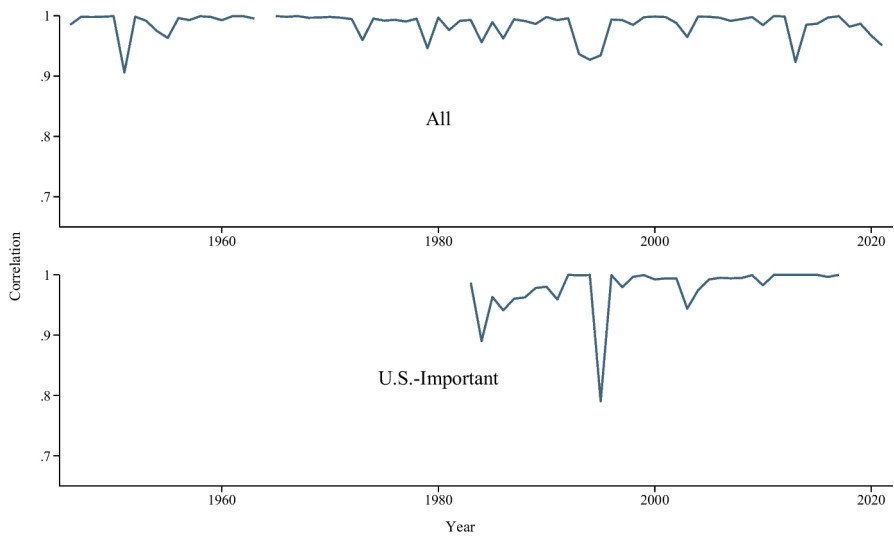


Fig. 7 Comparison of S -scores. Yearly correlations between UNGA-DM S -scores and BSV S -scores, both measuring alignment with the U.S. Correlations in the top panel are for S -scores based on all votes; correlations in the bottom panel are for S -scores based only on votes designated as important by the U.S. State Department. The gap in the top panel is 1964 when there were no roll-call votes. The limited coverage in the bottom panel reflects availability of State Department data

Overall, the correlations between S -scores are high (above 0.96 in both cases) but the figure illustrates substantial variation year-to-year.¹²

We repeat this exercise with another widely used measure based on policy preferences estimated with an item-response theory model proposed by Bailey et al. (2017). Using similar or identical draft resolutions in different sessions as bridging observations allows these authors to estimate ideal-points for UN member-states over time in a one dimensional policy space.¹³ Many empirical studies use distance from the U.S. ideal-point estimate to assess geopolitical proximity to the U.S. Using this distance measure, Fig. 8 repeats the exercise above of comparing datasets by examining the period-by-period correlation between measures we calculate using UNGA-DM data and measures BSV calculated using their data. Again, the overall correlation is high (even higher than with S -scores since the bridging observations are the same across datasets) but, especially for important votes, with substantial variation across sessions. We also explore differences between the “raw” ideal-point estimates by regressing one set of ideal-points on the other (see [supplementary material](#)).

As noted above, there are two sources of differences in the datasets that drive these differences in ideal-point estimates. First, the two datasets cover somewhat different sets of decisions; 6,202 roll-call vote decisions are covered by both datasets, but 1,284 roll-call vote decisions are covered only by one of the two (see Table A1 in supplementary materials for details). Second, where the decisions covered do

¹²There were no UNGA plenary session roll-call votes in 1964.

¹³A detailed discussion of this approach and some issues appears in the supplementary materials, where in Tables B4-B6 the full results are reported.

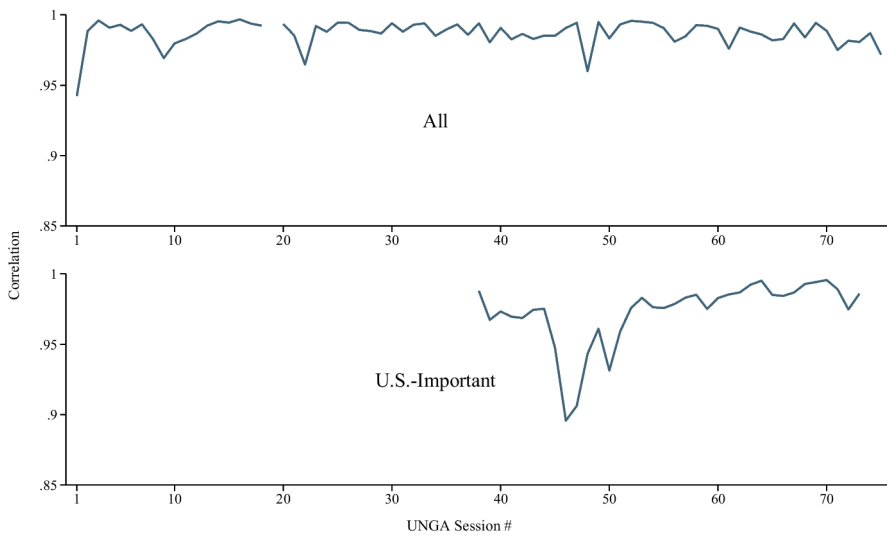


Fig. 8 Comparison of ideal-point distance. Session-by-session correlations between ideal-point distance from U.S. calculated with UNGA-DM data and ideal-point distance from the U.S. calculated with BSV data. Both measure geopolitical proximity to the U.S. Correlations in the top panel are for ideal-point distances based on all votes; correlations in the bottom panel are for ideal-point distances based only on votes designated as important by the U.S. State Department. The gap in the top panel is Regular Session 19 when there were no roll-call votes. The limited coverage in the bottom panel reflects availability of State Department data

overlap, there are 4,194 differences in what votes are recorded for individual countries. Taking these together at the country-vote level, there are 987,479 identical data points across the two datasets and 191,968 different data points.¹⁴

One difference between the datasets just discussed is not captured by the graphs above: decisions in BSV that are not included in UNGA-DM. UNGA-DM covers only resolution-related decisions in the UNGA. Although this is also the bulk of votes in BSV, it does include some procedural votes (e.g., motions to adjourn) not related to resolutions, and some votes that took place in committee rather than in the General Assembly.

Figure 9 tallies these irregular votes as a share of all votes in BSV that year. Large shares typically reflect years with few votes overall. For example, BSV includes seven votes for 1951. Two of these are not covered by UNGA-DM, a motion to adjourn the meeting and a recommendation to postpone considering whether an item should be included on the agenda. Comparing Fig. 5 with Fig. 9 shows that until 1974

¹⁴These include differences on resolution votes (both in terms of coverage and in terms of individual country-level votes), some of which are bridging observations. Dataset differences also result in slight differences in the availability of ideal point estimates for individual countries. In a few cases, the greater coverage of UNGA-DM allows ideal point estimation for countries where BSV does not (especially when looking just at important votes). Conversely, in a very small number of cases, BSV has ideal points for countries that did not vote. These are driven by data entry errors, e.g., votes by Nigeria being recorded as votes by Niger.

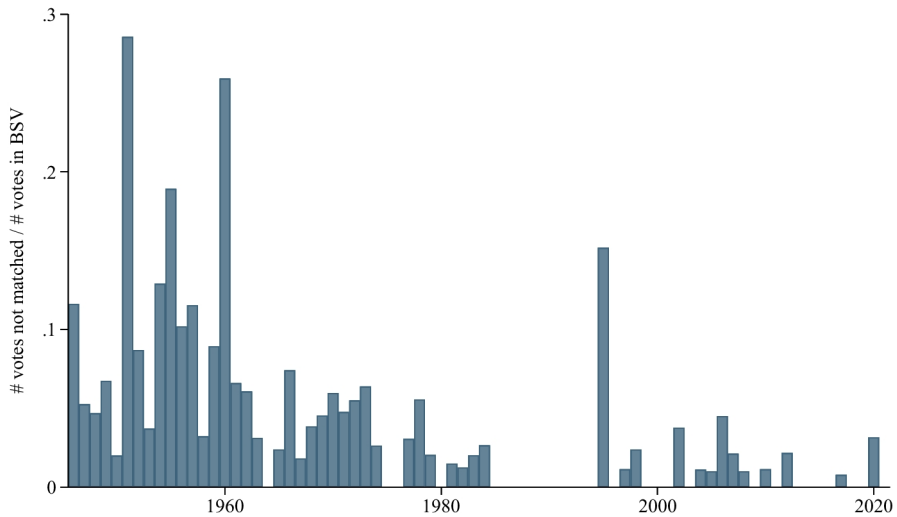


Fig. 9 Share of BSV decisions not resolution-related votes in UNGA. Yearly share of roll-call votes in BSV that are not in UNGA-DM (i.e., are not resolution-related votes in UNGA plenary sessions). Years with high values have few votes overall

BSV misses relatively few resolution-related recorded votes but includes more votes that are not resolution-related. After 1974, the pattern reverses.¹⁵

In addition to its consistent coverage of votes, UNGA-DM includes several unique features. As several scholars have noted (e.g., Häge & Hug, 2016), roll-call votes have changed in their frequency over time, and in recent years a push toward a more consensual UNGA has led to more decisions without a vote. As our data cover all resolution-related decisions, we can illustrate this tendency for different types of votes. Figure 10 depicts the share of decisions taken by roll-call vote (instead of by non-recorded vote or by consensus). For final passage votes on draft resolutions this share (solid line) started off quite low in the early years and picked up thereafter, eventually stabilizing around 25%.¹⁶ For other types of decisions, namely amendments, separate votes and motions, the share of roll-call votes was also quite low in some early sessions, then increases considerably over time.

For a subset of recorded votes it is also possible to identify which member-state requested the roll call. Figure 11, depicting the top quartile, shows that the Soviet Union/Russia leads the pack with many more requests than member-states like the U.S. and France. Surprisingly, Poland, Syria, and several others without a permanent seat in the UNSC also frequently request roll calls.

¹⁵The differences between BSV and UNGA-DM data discussed are those that matter for most researchers. Other differences include dates (disagreeing for seventy percent of observations) and which votes are flagged as important to the U.S. (BSV sometimes flags votes on draft resolutions rather than the motion, amendment, separate, or committee vote identified by the State Department report.)

¹⁶We use years instead of session numbers to facilitate including special and emergency special sessions.

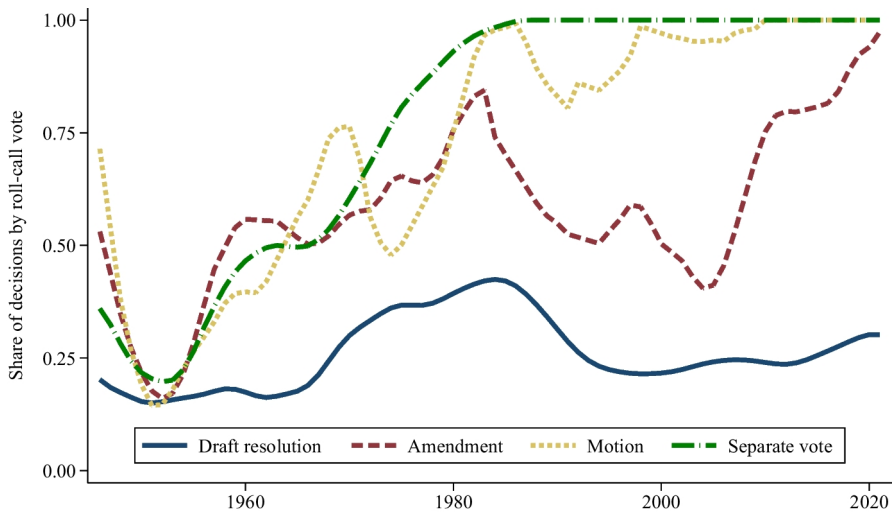


Fig. 10 Share of roll-call votes in the UNGA. Yearly share of decisions by roll-call vote, graphed separately for final passage decisions on draft resolutions, amendments, motions, and separate votes. Annual averages using UNGA-DM data and lowess smoothing with bin width of 0.2. Roll-call votes have become dominant prior to the final passage decision but draft resolution final passage decisions are still more often by consensus

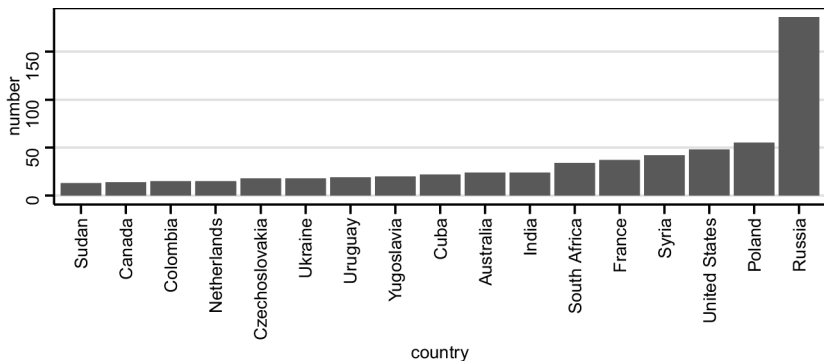


Fig. 11 Roll-call vote requests in the UNGA. Number of times member-state listed as requesting vote by roll call for most frequent cases

4 UNGA-DM: Organization, structure, and access

This section provides detail on the organization of the UNGA-DM database, the structure of the data, and how to access the data.

A key variable in the organization of the data is the *decision_id*, which, together with associated variables, allows users to follow the full process for each draft resolution (including amendments, motions, separate votes and the final passage vote). An example value of *decision_id* is A/RES/76/54-FP. Following UN protocol, A indicates UNGA plenary session, RES indicates resolution, 76 is the session number, and

54 is the resolution number. We add the -FP suffix to designate the final passage vote. Rather than ending with -FP, the *decision_id* for amendments has an -A, for motions -M, and for separate votes -S. Since multiple amendments, motions, and separate votes are possible, these are followed by numbers. Up through session 30, the UN numbered resolutions sequentially (rather than restarting each session), instead indicating the session via parenthetical Roman numerals. An example *decision_id* from session 15 is A/RES/1599(XV)-FP.

Tracing through an example of the sequence of decisions on a resolution may be helpful. On April 15, 1961, the UNGA addressed “The situation in the Congo” (related to decolonization) by considering a number of competing draft resolutions. On “the twenty-one-Power draft resolution” (A/L.339 and Add.1–5), the UNGA took a roll-call vote on the first half of an amendment proposed by the Congo (*decision_id* A/RES/1599(XV)-A0100), then a roll-call vote on the second half (A/RES/1599(XV)-A0200). Both halves were rejected (not meeting a 2/3 majority requirement). Next were separate votes on preambular paragraphs one to three (A/RES/1599(XV)-S0100 to A/RES/1599(XV)-S0300), all adopted by non-recorded votes. This was followed by four roll-call separate votes on operative paragraphs or parts thereof (A/RES/1599(XV)-S0400 to A/RES/1599(XV)-S0700), two of which passed and two of which failed. Finally, the draft resolution as a whole (minus the passages not approved via the separate votes) was adopted by roll-call vote (A/RES/1599(XV)-FP). Thus, the entire history of each resolution (or draft resolution if it ultimately did not pass) can be tracked.

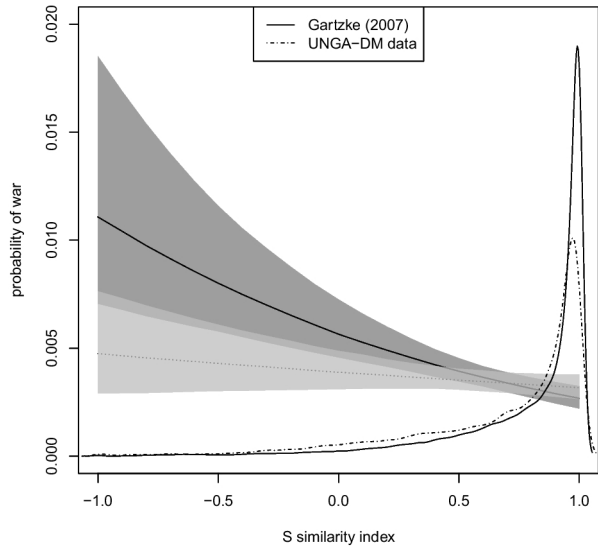
This structure provides researchers with considerable flexibility. Unlike with BSV, researchers can use all resolution-related decisions (including all those before final passage since these are often more contentious than final passage).¹⁷ For other questions, researchers can use UNGA-DM to accurately select the types of votes they wish to study. (For errors in BSV classification of non-final votes, see Table A1 in the supplemental materials.) Alternatively, one could use final passage when that is by roll call and a non-final passage vote when final passage was not by recorded vote to create a more comprehensive set of resolutions to analyze.¹⁸ Different choices are suitable for different applications; the structure of UNGA-DM allows each researcher to accurately customize the set of resolution-related decisions they analyze.

UNGA-DM includes a number of variables associated with each decision. We provide data in two formats at <https://unvotes.unige.ch>: via an SQL server and in comma separated value (.csv) format. On the SQL server, UNGA-DM data are organized into eight data frames. Users can construct queries (via the web portal or within software packages such as R and STATA) that join the data across the frames to build custom tables. In.csv format, we provide the data in two main files. In the first file, an observation is a decision (e.g., a vote on a draft resolution) and includes information such as: the *decision_id*; the UN symbols for the draft resolution, the resolution, and the meeting record (i.e., minutes) for the relevant UNGA plenary meeting; the page

¹⁷ Having access to all votes is particularly important for studies following the approach in Coggins and Morse (2024) to identify strategic absences based on all votes cast (or not cast) on a given day.

¹⁸ Of the 1059 draft resolutions that included non-final passage roll-call votes, in 248 cases final passage was by consensus or non-recorded vote.

Fig. 12 Replication of Gartzke (2007). Point estimates and 95 % confidence intervals for average predicted probability of war between state pairs at different values of “INTERESTS” variable (measured by S -scores calculated using UNGA voting). Darker line/band use original BSV data; lighter line/band use UNGA-DM data. The solid line density function indicates distribution of S -scores based on BSV data; the dashed line density function indicates distribution of S -scores based on UNGA-DM data



number in the meeting record; the date of the meeting; and whether the decision was designated as important by the U.S. This file covers all resolution-related decisions, whether by consensus, by non-recorded vote, or by recorded (roll-call) vote. In the second file, an observation is a member-state's vote in a given decision and includes the *decision_id*, the member-state's name/country code, the member-state's original vote, and the member-state's amended vote. This file covers resolution-related roll-call votes only. Observations for roll-call votes can be linked across the two files by *decision_id*. Finally, 14 additional decisions designated as important by the U.S. do not fit our inclusion criteria; these are provide in separate files that can be appended to the main dataset to give full coverage of U.S.-important votes. Our website includes a codebook that explains variable definitions in detail.

5 Replications

Next we provide replication studies to assess how the more complete coverage of the UNGA-DM dataset affects inferences researchers have drawn from their analyses. We present four article replications selected based on data considerations, the impact of using more complete data, the articles' importance (as reflected in Google Scholar citations), the field and issue area (to reflect this journal's focus on economics and political science), and the feasibility of replication. We include some studies using S -scores and some using ideal-point distant.¹⁹

The first replication is Gartzke's (2007) study on the liberal peace, which relies on S -scores. While Gartzke uses S -scores as a control, it is still instructive to consider its substantive effect on the probability of war between states. The lower solid and dashed lines in Fig. 12 depict the distribution of S values in the two datasets. The

¹⁹For details and three additional replication studies, see the [supplementary materials](#).

lines with confidence intervals report the average predicted probability of war at different S values. The figure shows that over most of its range the effect of the similarity measure on the probability of war is considerably smaller using UNGA-DM data. For full results, see Table B1 in the supplementary materials.

A number of studies exploring the geopolitics of foreign aid and international organizations also use alignment measures based on S -scores. Kilby (2011) studies Japanese and U.S. informal influence in the Asian Development Bank (ADB). Two key variables are UNGA voting concessions to the U.S. (diffUSA) and to Japan (diffJPN), both calculated from S -scores. We replicate the basic results which draw on an earlier version of BSV's data, and then use UNGA-DM data. Given appropriate control variables, a positive coefficient on diffUSA (diffJPN) indicates that countries making concessions to the U.S. (Japan) receive preferential treatment from the ADB. In Kilby's original results (Fig. 13 below; full results in Table B2 in the supplementary materials), the coefficient estimate is positive and significant for the U.S. but not for Japan. The outcome reverses using UNGA-DM data. This substantively important change points to Japanese influence as predominant, more in-line with the qualitative literature and the particulars of the ADB.

Dreher et al. (2022) explore U.S. vote buying in the UNSC. They argue that in the case of allied countries (where direct transfers are uncontroversial) the U.S. pays for UNSC votes with bilateral aid. In the case of non-allied countries (where direct transfers are controversial), the U.S. instead orchestrates indirect payment via international financial institutions. The authors use UNGA voting to place countries on a continuum from not voting with the U.S. in the several years prior (non-allied) to always voting with the U.S. (allied). A key test in the paper (Fig. 3, notes) demonstrates that U.S. bilateral aid and IMF/World Bank multilateral lending react differently to UNSC voting. Using BSV data, they reject the null hypothesis that bilateral

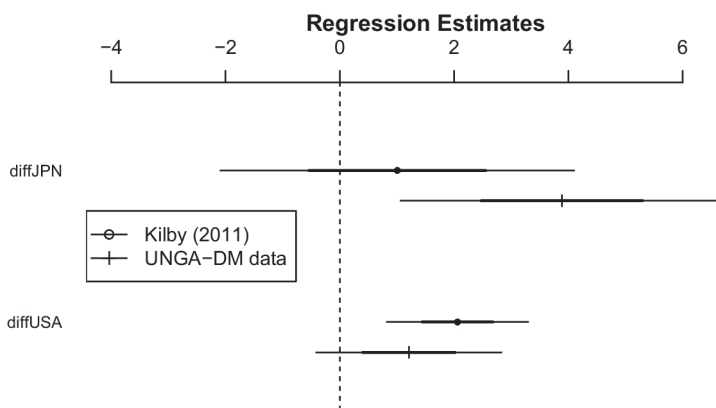


Fig. 13 Replication of Kilby (2011). Coefficient estimates and 95 % confidence intervals for concessions in UNGA voting in model of disbursements from the Asian Development Bank. DiffUSA is alignment with U.S. on important votes minus alignment with U.S. on other votes. DiffJPN is alignment with Japan on important votes minus alignment with Japan on other votes. This difference is used to measure voting concessions to the major power (i.e., movement toward the major power's position on important votes). Alignment measured by S -scores, computed either with BSV (in original paper) or UNGA-DM data

and multilateral are the same for both IMF and World Bank lending using one-sided tests (IMF: p -value=0.005; World Bank: p -value=0.048). Using UNGA-DM, the results strengthen (IMF: p -value=0.0002; World Bank: p -value=0.0095) and both would also pass a two-sided test (IMF: p -value=0.0003; World Bank: p -value=0.019). Full results in Table B3 in the supplementary materials.

While these studies rely on voting similarity measures, many others use policy preferences or differences in policy preferences based on ideal-point estimates from Bailey et al. (2017). Clark and Dolan (2021) use this latter approach to assess how U.S. preferences shape World Bank conditionality. The study asks whether World Bank borrowers that are closer to the U.S. in terms of policy preferences (measured by ideal-point distances) are dealt with more leniently, i.e., subject to fewer prior actions across a narrower range of categories.

Figure 14 depicts the average expected number of prior actions (left panels) and categories (right panels) based on BSV data and on UNGA-DM data (without controls (top panels) or with controls (bottom panels)). While the substantive effects are similar—increasing ideological distance from the U.S. is associated with stricter conditionality—using UNGA-DM data leads to more uncertainty in the estimated effects. This is due to the fact, as also depicted in Fig. 14, that the variance in the ideal-point distance estimates based on the UNGA-DM is smaller than for the BSV data. This reduced variance is evident in the narrower range of ideal-point distances in the estimation sample using UNGA-DM data.²⁰

6 Conclusion

UNGA voting offers a glimpse at how member-states position themselves on the world stage. Hence, it is not surprising that since the early years of the UN scholars have used these votes to study myriad aspects of member-states and their behavior. Unfortunately, oftentimes the data used are incomplete, with coverage of different categories of votes varying arbitrarily over time. UNGA-DM, by using systematic criteria and offering exhaustive coverage, provides a more complete view of state behavior. As the replication studies show, this can impact inferences drawn from analyses using these data. The UNGA-DM data also offers a more comprehensive set of variables tracking UNGA decision-making. The depth and breadth of the dataset will put research using UNGA votes on more solid ground and allow researchers greater flexibility to explore novel and important questions.

²⁰The methodology behind ideal-point estimation should generate the same variance in ideal-point estimates (and hence roughly the same range of ideal-point estimate values) across the population—that is, considering all countries and all years—whether using BSV or UNGA-DM data. However, the Clark and Dolan setting is different in two ways. First, they use ideal-point distance from the U.S., not “raw” ideal-point estimates. Second, the estimation sample is limited to 2005–2018 and only those countries with World Bank development policy loan approvals. For this specific group of observations, the range of ideal-point distance estimates are indeed different.

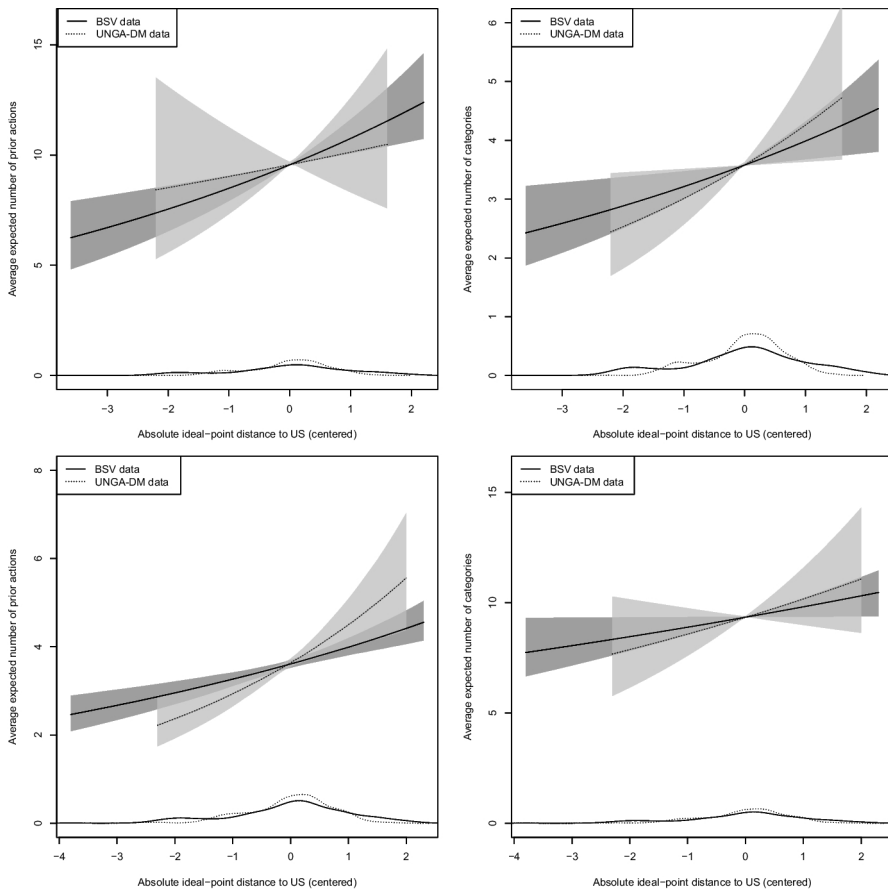


Fig. 14 Replication of Clark and Dolan (2021). Effects of ideal-point distance on World Bank conditions (prior actions (left panels) and number of categories (right panel) without (top row) and with controls (bottom row)). Darker lines/bands use original BSV data; lighter lines/bands use UNGA-DM data. Solid line density functions indicates distribution of (centered) ideal-point distance estimates based on BSV data; dashed line density functions indications distribution of (centered) ideal-point distance estimates based on UNGA-DM data

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Data availability Data are available at <https://unvotes.unige.ch/>

Declarations

Conflict of interest/competing interest The authors have no conflict of interest or competing interests related to this paper or data set.

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